

UAE & Saudi Arabia Salary & Hiring Guide

2026

Salary benchmarks, hiring outlook and talent intelligence for employers and candidates.

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2026 GCC SALARY & HIRING GUIDE

A selective UAE market. A tighter Saudi market.

Across both markets, employers are prioritising capability and delivery evidence over title inflation. Generalist talent pools remain broad, while scarcity is concentrated in specialist, transformation and leadership roles.

UAE**Selective**

Deep candidate supply supports employer choice in many generalist roles. Scarcity remains concentrated in high-impact specialists and proven leaders.

Saudi Arabia**Expansionary**

Project-led growth, localisation and transformation continue to increase demand for senior and specialist capability.

Compensation**Role-specific**

Broad market inflation is less useful than live role benchmarking. Scope, sector, scarcity and package design drive the real range.

Generalist Talent**Available**

Finance, HR and mainstream commercial hiring generally have wider candidate pools, especially in the UAE.

Specialist Talent**Tighter**

Cyber, AI, enterprise architecture, cloud, ERP transformation and major-project leadership remain harder to secure.

Executive Search**Selective**

Boards and leadership teams are placing more weight on transformation track record, local context and measurable delivery.

ION TALENT VIEW**The market is not short of candidates. It is short of the right evidence.**

The strongest 2026 searches are being won by employers that define the mandate clearly, benchmark the package before launch and move quickly once they find candidates with evidence of delivery. For candidates, generic experience is increasingly less persuasive than proof of outcomes, scale and ownership.

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Same region. Different hiring mechanics.

A Dubai and Riyadh role should not be benchmarked the same way simply because the title matches. Candidate supply, localisation, relocation and mandate can change the market materially.

DIMENSION	UAE	SAUDI ARABIA
Hiring climate	Active and selective	Expansionary and tighter
Generalist candidate supply	Deep	Moderate to deep
Specialist availability	Tighter at senior levels	Tighter across more categories
Compensation pressure	Targeted by scarcity	More visible in growth roles
Localisation	Emiratisation workforce planning	Saudisation and occupation-level planning
Mobility	Global talent hub	Relocation proposition matters more
Executive hiring	Strong regional pool	National leadership and transformation depth

Localisation

Treat Emiratisation and Saudisation as workforce-design inputs before search launch. Role classification, workforce mix and hiring sequence can affect the available market and the final package.

Candidate mobility

UAE-to-KSA moves are usually strongest when the candidate sees a clear step-up in mandate, visibility or career value. Family logistics and total package can change the decision materially.

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Construction, engineering & project delivery

Major programmes, infrastructure, real estate and industrial investment keep project-delivery leadership central to GCC hiring. The strongest premium sits with candidates who can combine technical depth, commercial control and delivery at scale.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Project Manager	AED 25-45k / month AED 300-540k / year	SAR 25-45k / month SAR 300-540k / year
Construction Manager	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-50k / month SAR 360-600k / year
Engineering Manager	AED 35-50k / month AED 420-600k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Commercial / Contracts Manager	AED 35-50k / month AED 420-600k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Planning / Project Controls Manager	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-50k / month SAR 360-600k / year
Construction Director	AED 50-70k / month AED 600-840k / year	SAR 50-80k / month SAR 600-960k / year
Project / Programme Director	AED 55-80k / month AED 660-960k / year	SAR 60-90k / month SAR 720-1,080k / year

Typical roles also include Design Manager, MEP leadership, Quantity Surveying, HSE leadership, Civil / Structural leadership and specialist engineering disciplines. Sector, project value and client-side vs contractor scope can move pay materially.

ION TALENT VIEW**DEMAND: HIGH****AVAILABILITY: MODERATE / TIGHT**

Project and construction management talent is broad at mid-level, but search friction rises materially for project directors, commercial leaders, project controls specialists and engineering leaders with major-programme, complex stakeholder or client-side experience.

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Finance & accounting

Finance hiring remains broad, but the strongest candidates increasingly combine technical control with transformation, commercial partnership and stakeholder influence.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Financial Analyst	AED 15-25k / month AED 180-300k / year	SAR 15-25k / month SAR 180-300k / year
Finance Manager	AED 25-40k / month AED 300-480k / year	SAR 25-40k / month SAR 300-480k / year
Financial Controller	AED 25-50k / month AED 300-600k / year	SAR 35-50k / month SAR 420-600k / year
Head / Chief Internal Audit	AED 40-70k / month AED 480-840k / year	SAR 50-75k / month SAR 600-900k / year
Finance Director	AED 50-85k / month AED 600-1,020k / year	SAR 55-80k / month SAR 660-960k / year
Chief Financial Officer	AED 65-110k / month AED 780-1,320k / year	SAR 85-140k / month SAR 1,020-1,680k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: STEADY / HIGH

AVAILABILITY: MODERATE

Candidate supply is healthy at many levels. Scarcity rises around transformation-led finance leaders, high-quality FP&A / business partnering, specialist audit and leaders with credible sector depth. In Saudi Arabia, localisation adds another workforce-planning layer.

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Sales & commercial

Commercial hiring rewards proof: market access, pipeline creation, enterprise deal cycles and the ability to convert opportunity into revenue in a crowded GCC market.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Key Account Manager	AED 15-30k / month AED 180-360k / year	SAR 20-30k / month SAR 240-360k / year
Business Development Manager	AED 18-30k / month AED 216-360k / year	SAR 25-35k / month SAR 300-420k / year
Sales Manager	AED 18-35k / month AED 216-420k / year	SAR 25-35k / month SAR 300-420k / year
Business Development Director	AED 30-50k / month AED 360-600k / year	SAR 50-60k / month SAR 600-720k / year
Sales Director	AED 30-60k / month AED 360-720k / year	SAR 55-65k / month SAR 660-780k / year
VP Sales / Commercial Director	AED 50-75k / month AED 600-900k / year	SAR 65-75k / month SAR 780-900k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: HIGH

AVAILABILITY: MIXED

Generalist sales profiles are abundant; proven enterprise and solutions sellers are not. Strong candidates can evidence account growth, new-logo wins, complex deal cycles and sector access. In Saudi Arabia, localisation should be checked before the search strategy is finalised.

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HR & people

People functions are being pulled in two directions: cost discipline on generalist hiring and heavier expectations around workforce planning, localisation and transformation.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
HR Generalist / Advisor	AED 18-25k / month AED 216-300k / year	SAR 18-25k / month SAR 216-300k / year
Talent Acquisition Manager	AED 30-40k / month AED 360-480k / year	SAR 30-40k / month SAR 360-480k / year
HR Business Partner	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-45k / month SAR 360-540k / year
HR Manager	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-45k / month SAR 360-540k / year
Reward / L&D Manager	AED 35-50k / month AED 420-600k / year	SAR 35-50k / month SAR 420-600k / year
HR Director	AED 50-80k / month AED 600-960k / year	SAR 55-95k / month SAR 660-1,140k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: SELECTIVE

AVAILABILITY: MODERATE

Senior HR value is shifting toward workforce strategy, organisation design, reward, national talent development and credible partnering with business leadership. Generalist pools are wider, particularly in the UAE.

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Project, programme & transformation

Corporate transformation, operating-model change and portfolio delivery require more than project tenure. Employers are paying for governance, adoption and executive-level delivery confidence.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Project Manager	AED 25-40k / month AED 300-480k / year	SAR 25-40k / month SAR 300-480k / year
PMO Manager	AED 30-45k / month AED 360-540k / year	SAR 30-45k / month SAR 360-540k / year
Programme Manager	AED 35-55k / month AED 420-660k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Transformation Manager	AED 35-50k / month AED 420-600k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Head of PMO	AED 45-65k / month AED 540-780k / year	SAR 45-70k / month SAR 540-840k / year
Transformation Director	AED 50-75k / month AED 600-900k / year	SAR 55-80k / month SAR 660-960k / year
Strategy / Transformation Director	AED 55-85k / month AED 660-1,020k / year	SAR 60-90k / month SAR 720-1,080k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: HIGH

AVAILABILITY: MODERATE / TIGHT

The strongest candidates can translate strategy into a controlled delivery portfolio, influence senior stakeholders and show measurable adoption. Scarcity rises for large-scale transformation leaders with cross-functional ownership and a track record beyond a single system implementation.

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Technology, digital & cybersecurity

Technology is deep enough to deserve extra detail, but the guide keeps it to two pages. On this page: engineering delivery and security leadership.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Software Engineer / Developer - mid	AED 20-30k / month AED 240-360k / year	SAR 20-35k / month SAR 240-420k / year
Engineering Manager	AED 35-60k / month AED 420-720k / year	SAR 40-50k / month SAR 480-600k / year
VP / Director of Engineering	AED 55-85k / month AED 660-1,020k / year	SAR 50-90k / month SAR 600-1,080k / year
Information Security Engineer	AED 20-45k / month AED 240-540k / year	SAR 20-40k / month SAR 240-480k / year
Security / InfoSec Architect	AED 25-60k / month AED 300-720k / year	SAR 30-65k / month SAR 360-780k / year
Head of Information Security	AED 35-70k / month AED 420-840k / year	SAR 45-70k / month SAR 540-840k / year
Chief Information Security Officer	AED 50-100k / month AED 600-1,200k / year	SAR 65-160k / month SAR 780-1,920k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: VERY HIGH

AVAILABILITY: MODERATE / TIGHT

The broad engineering market is deeper than the architecture and security-leadership market. Search friction rises when technical depth must be combined with enterprise stakeholder ownership, regulated-sector context, critical infrastructure or transformation at scale.

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Cloud, data, AI, enterprise architecture & ERP

This is where specialist scarcity is most concentrated: production AI, cloud architecture, enterprise design and enterprise-platform transformation.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK

Typical fixed monthly cash/package. Annual figure = monthly range x 12. Variable pay and non-fixed benefits excluded.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Cloud Engineer	AED 15-40k / month AED 180-480k / year	SAR 20-35k / month SAR 240-420k / year
Cloud Architect	AED 40-60k / month AED 480-720k / year	SAR 30-45k / month SAR 360-540k / year
Data Engineer	AED 20-35k / month AED 240-420k / year	SAR 20-35k / month SAR 240-420k / year
AI / Machine Learning Engineer	AED 25-60k / month AED 300-720k / year	SAR 30-60k / month SAR 360-720k / year
Head of Data / Analytics	AED 50-75k / month AED 600-900k / year	SAR 50-75k / month SAR 600-900k / year
Enterprise Architect	AED 40-60k / month AED 480-720k / year	SAR 45-75k / month SAR 540-900k / year
ERP / SAP / Oracle Lead	AED 30-50k / month AED 360-600k / year	SAR 35-55k / month SAR 420-660k / year
Head of Enterprise Applications	AED 50-70k / month AED 600-840k / year	SAR 40-70k / month SAR 480-840k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: VERY HIGH

AVAILABILITY: TIGHT

Employers are separating tool familiarity from production capability. The premium sits with candidates who can design at enterprise scale, govern complexity and show deployed outcomes. SAP S/4HANA, Oracle Fusion, cloud security and enterprise architecture remain especially search-intensive.

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Executive & C-Suite

Executive ranges are deliberately broad. Ownership model, scale, mandate, governance load, sector and variable / equity design can change total reward materially.

2026 ION TALENT BENCHMARK Fixed monthly cash only. Bonus, equity / LTI and other benefits sit outside the table.

ROLE / LEVEL	UAE · FIXED CASH	SAUDI ARABIA · FIXED CASH
Chief Financial Officer	AED 65-110k / month AED 780-1,320k / year	SAR 85-140k / month SAR 1,020-1,680k / year
Chief Information Officer	AED 65-80k / month AED 780-960k / year	SAR 90-200k / month SAR 1,080-2,400k / year
Chief Technology Officer	AED 60-150k / month AED 720-1,800k / year	SAR 60-180k / month SAR 720-2,160k / year
Chief Information Security Officer	AED 50-100k / month AED 600-1,200k / year	SAR 65-160k / month SAR 780-1,920k / year
Chief Human Resources Officer	AED 85-150k / month AED 1,020-1,800k / year	SAR 100-140k / month SAR 1,200-1,680k / year
Chief Marketing Officer	AED 70-100k / month AED 840-1,200k / year	SAR 95-180k / month SAR 1,140-2,160k / year
Managing Director / General Manager	AED 70-120k / month AED 840-1,440k / year	SAR 80-150k / month SAR 960-1,800k / year

ION TALENT VIEW

DEMAND: SELECTIVE

AVAILABILITY: TIGHT AT PROVEN SCALE

Boards and leadership teams are placing more weight on transformation track record, succession depth, local context and measurable delivery. In Saudi Arabia, senior hiring increasingly needs an explicit plan for national leadership pipelines alongside immediate capability.

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Where search friction is highest.

The hardest GCC searches usually combine scarce capability with a high-stakes mandate. The role may not be rare on paper, but the evidence required can make the true market very small.

01

AI / production ML

Deployment, governance and business adoption

02

Cyber & cloud security

Architecture, identity, DevSecOps and regulated environments

03

Enterprise architecture

Technology depth plus enterprise stakeholder ownership

04

ERP transformation

S/4HANA, Oracle Fusion and multi-entity delivery

05

Major-project leadership

Project directors, commercial leaders and project controls

06

Enterprise sales

Proven GCC revenue, complex deal cycles and sector access

07

Transformation leadership

Cross-functional ownership, governance and adoption

08

Executive leadership

Scale, local context and measurable transformation track record

CANDIDATE MOBILITY · ION TALENT VIEW

A KSA move must be sold on more than salary.

For UAE-based candidates, Saudi opportunities become compelling when the role offers a clear step-up in mandate, visibility or long-term career value. Housing, schooling, medical cover, travel, bonus structure and family logistics can materially change the decision. Compare total package and scope, not monthly fixed pay in isolation.

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Package design matters more in 2026.

Salary remains central, but candidates increasingly evaluate the entire proposition: mandate, fixed cash, bonus, benefits, relocation, flexibility and career value.

UAE package design

For many professional roles the market remains selective rather than inflationary. Employers should be clear on what sits inside fixed monthly cash and what sits outside it. Schooling, flights, medical, bonus and equity can change the perceived value of an offer materially.

Saudi package design

Relocation packages need more deliberate design. The strongest offers align fixed cash with role mandate, family logistics and a clear reason to move. Senior candidates often assess housing, schooling, travel and decision authority as part of the same choice.

Emiratisation

Treat Emiratisation as a workforce-planning input, not a year-end check. Hiring teams should validate how the target applies to the entity, workforce and role before the search launches.

Saudisation

Saudi localisation is increasingly role-specific. Role classification and workforce planning should be checked before a search is scoped, particularly in functions subject to occupation-level requirements.

ION TALENT VIEW

Benchmark the role before you brief the market.

The most avoidable hiring problem is launching a search before the organisation agrees the role scope, localisation position and full compensation envelope. That creates rework, weakens candidate confidence and makes strong profiles harder to close.

2026 GCC SALARY & HIRING GUIDE

How to use the guide.

Salary data is useful only when it changes a hiring or career decision. These are the practical implications ION Talent would take into a live mandate.

FOR EMPLOYERS

Build the offer before the shortlist.

- **Benchmark scope, not title.**
Team size, reporting line, budget and mandate can move the range materially.
- **Separate fixed and variable cash.**
State what is included in the monthly figure and what sits outside it.
- **Put localisation into workforce design early.**
Validate the role before the search launches.
- **Move faster on scarce profiles.**
AI, cyber, architecture, ERP, major-project and transformation talent can disappear quickly.
- **Design the KSA relocation proposition.**
Housing, education, flights, medical and family logistics can matter as much as fixed salary.
- **Use live market mapping.**
The narrower the talent pool, the less useful a generic salary range becomes.

FOR CANDIDATES

Sell impact, not just experience.

- **Match your benchmark to the role's real scope.**
Title alone is a poor guide to value.
- **Compare total package.**
Fixed cash is only one part of GCC compensation, especially for relocation and executive roles.
- **Quantify outcomes.**
Revenue, savings, delivery speed, risk reduction and transformation scale travel better than generic responsibilities.
- **Make specialist capability concrete.**
Employers want evidence of production use, judgment and business adoption.
- **Know localisation constraints.**
Eligibility can affect the live market for a title.
- **For KSA moves, negotiate scope as well as money.**
Decision authority and career trajectory can justify a move more than a marginal uplift.

ONE RULE TO KEEP

A salary guide is a starting point, not a substitute for live market mapping.

The narrower the talent pool, the more useful live search intelligence becomes: who is actually available, what they are earning, what they will move for and what competing employers are offering.

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How to read the salary benchmarks.

- **Compensation basis:** ranges represent typical fixed monthly cash/package benchmarks in AED or SAR. They are not a guaranteed base salary and generally exclude bonus, equity / LTI and non-fixed benefits.
- **Role selection:** representative roles were chosen around ION Talent's target functions and seniority levels. Titles are normalised where market naming differs between employers.
- **Range construction:** bands synthesise current market evidence into practical hiring ranges rather than false point estimates. Wider bands reflect genuine variation in mandate, sector, scale and ownership.
- **Annual figures:** monthly range x 12. No exchange-rate conversion is used between AED and SAR.
- **Market commentary:** commentary reflects ION Talent's interpretation of 2026 hiring conditions and should be used alongside live search intelligence.
- **Research cut-off:** 9 September 2026.

Disclaimer

This guide is general market information, not legal, tax, immigration or compensation advice. Salary outcomes depend on company size, sector, location, experience, nationality / localisation eligibility, role scope, benefits and market timing. Localisation rules can be occupation- and establishment-specific and may change. Employers should validate current requirements before making employment decisions.

ION Talent

Hiring in the UAE or Saudi Arabia?

ION Talent combines direct search, live market mapping and practical compensation intelligence to help employers hire senior, specialist and hard-to-find talent.

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info@iontalentgroup.com | iontalentgroup.com